

INTERVIEW | **DAVID MORGAN**

'In a year, you may see a four-day Test'

In an exclusive interview ICC President David Morgan spoke to INDIA TODAY Deputy Editor SHARDA UGRA about the future of cricket. Excerpts:

Q. Are you worried about player surveys done this year where up to 30 per cent said they believed Tests would be obsolete in 20 years....

A. I am not worried by surveys of this kind, I think it's good that they are undertaken and it's important that we look carefully at the results. But the board of the ICC is determined to ensure that Test match cricket is seen as the pinnacle of our great game. I believe we are extra fortunate to have three properties at international level in one game—Test match, 50-over and Twenty20. The challenge for us is to make optimum use of all of them.

Q. What is being done on the ground to strengthen Test cricket?

A. We need better over-rates, better pitches that give a good balance between bat and ball and we need to consider day-night Test match cricket... the issue is the colour of the ball and the quality of the ball. It would be a pity if day-night Test match cricket had to be played with a white ball and, therefore, coloured clothing. Another thought that many people have, that we are examining is whether Test match cricket can

be played over four days rather than five.

Q. How quickly will that happen?

A. The mental shift has been made, it has been talked about and examined. I would be very surprised if within a year you haven't seen some significant changes in Test cricket. Over rates, pitches, day-night Tests ... in a year's time you will see for yourself changes that have occurred in Test cricket.

Q. But surely, a child growing up today will be hooked to T20 not Tests?

A. I don't worry too much about that, because if you think about it all of us started playing 10-over or five-over cricket. When somebody makes it as a potential first-class cricketer they certainly do aspire to the top level of the game. A 30-year-old Test match cricketer who is perhaps not sure of his place in his country's Test XI yes, he is going to be tempted to play IPL cricket. But is there anything wrong in that? I don't think there is.

Q. So, where are these surveys coming from? They can't all be 30-year-olds unsure of their Test places...

A. I should think a number of them are... if not 30-year-olds, then certainly 28-plus...

Q. Andrew Symonds is going to be the first freelance T20 player—will he become the prototype of the profes-



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sional cricketer of the future?

A. Andrew Symonds is a significant entertainer and will be missed during the Ashes, so perhaps we oughtn't think of him as an example. But I do believe there will be cricketers who, after they have played a certain amount of international cricket but are not seen as permanent members of their international sides, will play state, county, the IPL, will go where they can earn a living. That is not a bad thing.

Q. What is the ICC's view of domes-

estic T20 event called the T20 Big Bash. Just after the ICC World T20, Victoria announced they had signed West Indian Dwayne Bravo and Gilbert's NSW was linked with Shahid Afridi.

Cricket 2011 may well look like this: the IPL will occupy two months in March-April, the P20 slotted in somewhere from June to September, and the SPL straddling the southern summer anytime from October to March, with the Champions League squeezed

in between. With all these options, could professional cricketers be bothered to turn out for his country, for Tests and ODIs?

Cricket turns up its nose at the idea that in two decades, cricketers may not choose to play for their country. The 'primacy' of Test cricket, its moral and technical superiority is somehow expected to ensure survival from the assault of the market. Sri Lankan captain Kumara Sangakkara says, "T20 has brought new revenues into the game...

but Tests should be the preferred format and occupy the prime spot. No one will go around saying you made 2,000 runs in Twenty20, but they will definitely remember you for making 10,000 runs in Test cricket."

Sangakkara is 31, steeped in Test tradition, but how about a 10-year-old today who is surrounded by Twenty20 and the IPL? Cricketer turned commentator Ian Bishop has heard young West Indians talk dismissively of "that Test match stuff". A key member of all